

## Sony ATRAC CD Walkman D-NF611

CD MP3 players do not cost a bomb, and use easily available inexpensive media, most play MP3 and audio CDs, and some can also play VCDs. Apart from being a little bulky and not as portable as their solid-state counterparts, the main issue to consider is skipping. Most new CD MP3 players do come with electronic skip protection that takes care of this problem. Here is our take on the Sony ATRAC CD Walkman D-NF611.

The Sony D-NF611 is encased in a plastic silver body and the front panel features a dot-matrix LCD, a four-way navigation and playback key, a jog dial and five other keys. The LCD displays the track ID3 information, battery status, file number, playing time, etc. A hold button at the rear prevents accidental button pressing.

Apart from the standard MP3 and audio-CD formats, the Sony D-NF611 supports ATRAC3plus and ATRAC3. ATRAC3 (Adaptive Transform Acoustic Coding3) is a proprietary compression format that satisfies the need for high sound quality and compression rates. Available transfer bit rates for ATRAC3 are 132, 105 and 66 Kbps, while ATRAC3plus supports 64 and 48 Kbps. However, these formats are not playable on a computer. Since the player supports both CD-R and CD-RW disks, you can use the bundled SonicStage Simple Burner Software to convert your existing audio CDs or MP3 tracks to ATRAC3plus or ATRAC3 formats and burn them onto a CD-RW to maximise the playtime. We were able to accommodate about 275 tracks on a standard 700 MB CD-RW using ATRAC3plus at 64 Kbps.

As far as playback options are concerned, you can play tracks at random, repeat a single track, play tracks within a selected group,

play bookmarks of tracks, or selected playlists. The device supports m3u playlists burnt onto MP3 CDs. Depending upon the format of the CD, you can add bookmarks for a fixed number of tracks for up to 10 CDs. A button at the side of the device allows you to increase bass by two levels, and also activate the automatic volume limiter system.

The D-NF611 also features an FM and AM tuner, and you can preset up to 30 stations for FM and 10 for AM. To ensure a skip-free operation, the player has a two-level G-Protection function—one for normal use, and the other enhanced level for use while jogging and exercising. This can be controlled from a small switch found under the lid of the player.

You can power the device using two AA batteries, or the bundled AC adaptor for tethered playback. Measuring 136 x 25.4 x 156 mm and weighing 215 gms, the player is a hefty bundle to carry around, especially as there is no carry case provided. There is provision to attach a strap though.

Audio quality is excellent and the bundled stereo earphones reproduce sound with great clarity. However, even considering its impressive features, this baby may seem a tad overpriced at close to Rs 10,000.

**Price:** Rs 9,990

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| Sony ATRAC D-NF611 |           | A |
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| Performance        | ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ |   |
| Features           | ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ |   |
| Value for money    | ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ |   |
| Ease of use        | ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ |   |

modes, but since there is no LCD, you have to rely on your ears to know what mode you chose. No LCD also means that neither song information, nor battery status is available. A few beeps and a red indicator light warn you that its time to change the single AAA battery. On the other hand, no battery-guzzling LCD also means longer battery life, and we logged a whopping 14 hours of continuous music—much higher than the rated 10 hours.

Audio output using the bundled earphones was extremely good, and with the reference headphones, even better. Output was extremely clear, though a tad sharp using the bundled earphones. However, the psa[64 lost out in data transfer speed. It took us 3 minutes and 39 seconds to transfer 50 MB of music using Windows Explorer.

To sum it up, the ruggedness, good audio quality, long battery life and made-for-sport design of the psa[64 is suitable for all athletes and fitness freaks who love music while working out. However, the lack of an LCD screen and portable storage mode may not make it appealing to a wider audience.

- + Good audio quality
- + Rugged and innovative design
- + Long battery life
- No LCD
- No portable storage option
- No playlist or folder support

**Price:** Rs 8,500

| Philips Nike psa[64 |           | B |
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| Performance         | ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ |   |
| Features            | ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ |   |
| Value for money     | ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ |   |
| Ease of use         | ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ |   |

## Samsung Digital Audio Player yepp YP-90S

### Yepp, it's expensive!

The mango-shaped Samsung yepp YP-90S is tiny and light, and sports a silver finish. The feature set is very similar to the LX100, boasting MP3 and WMA playback, voice recording and an FM radio. A circular backlit display on the front shows you the name of the audio-file playing, or the mode selected. Volume controls and a record button are also located on the front panel. A jog switch and a mode button are placed on the side, along with the USB connection. The jog switch is used for playing functions and scrolling, while the mode button gives access to the menu.

To connect the YP-90S to your computer, you need to install the bundled yepp explorer. You also get the yepp CD Ripper that can be used to convert audio CDs into MP3 and WMA. The device does not show up as a removable drive, and yepp Explorer is the only way to access the internal memory. Although you can transfer other file types onto the device, it's a little pointless as the other PC should also have yepp Explorer loaded to be able to read the memory.

There is no folder or playlist support, which isn't really needed for a 64 MB device that can only store 12 MP3s encoded at 160 Kbps. It requires two AAA batteries, and a new set lasted just over 11 hours—as opposed to the 15 hours suggested by the vendor.

Apart from shuffle and repeat, an intro mode is also available. You can choose between four preset equalizer modes, or customise bass and treble. The FM tuner comes with 10 presets, but struggles with less powerful stations. Voice recording is done in WAV format